

call if they are trying to share a single connection.

## PC

Refer to your company's policy for specifics on purchasing a computer or laptop. Since this will your main mode of working and communicating, be sure the specs and speed fit your optimal way of working.

## Camera with video capability

In an all-remote setting, video calls are vital to maintaining close relationships with clients, partners, and colleagues. While voice calls are flexible and allow for uniquely efficient lifestyles (e.g. listening to a conference call while running in a park), it's important to integrate video into workplace communication.

There are generally three tiers of camera quality for at-home workspaces (professional studio rigs notwithstanding).

1. Mirrorless camera or DSLR with dedicated lens (high-end)
1. Dedicated USB webcam (mid-tier)
1. Built-in webcam on a phone, laptop, or external display (baseline)

## Mirrorless or DSLR camera

For optimal image quality in video calls, a dedicated mirrorless camera or DSLR is the ideal. The Verge maintains a basic setup guide if you're new to the concept. Sony's Alpha line of mirrorless cameras are excellent for webcam use. However, these types of cameras and their accessories can be very expensive, and may not be right for everyone's needs. Before committing, read the following considerations.

1. Make sure your camera supports constant AC power (typically via micro-USB). If not, order a dummy adapter which slots in your battery compartment.
1. Determine if you need a USB capture card, which converts a camera's HDMI video output stream into a Zoom-friendly webcam stream. Many manufacturers, like Sony and Nikon, are releasing software that negates the need for this added piece of hardware.
1. Toggle the right settings. Put your camera in movie mode, enable clean HDMI output (so you don't have menu icons in your webcam feed), disable Auto Power Off, enable servo tracking (if applicable), enable continuous face tracking (if available), and tweak the exposure and white balance to create a normalized image based on your room's lighting conditions.
1. Don't skimp on a mounting solution. You'll need a heavy duty desk clamp, such as the Manfrotto 035RL, and articulating arm like the Impact 3 Section to manage the heft of a mirrorless camera or DSLR with lens attached.

## Optimized webcam or manufacturer camera setup

Most phones and laptops come with passable webcams direct from the manufacturer. If you're on a budget or travel often, this may be the best option for you. However, built-in cameras do not offer optimal quality.

If you take frequent video calls in your home workspace, a dedicated webcam like the Logitech

Brio Ultra HD Pro offers a higher resolution camera compared to built-in cameras, and is better able to handle low-light scenarios. Many dedicated webcams also include a software suite for touching up one's appearance, tweaking white balance, and applying background themes when paired with a green screen. These are also less complicated to install and maintain compared with mirrorless/DSLR rigs.

Consider selecting a webcam with a versatile mount, enabling it to be set atop a desktop monitor as well as a laptop. You can greatly improve the output from a dedicated webcam by focusing on good lighting.

Whether you're working with a webcam or the built-in device camera, you can optimize your space for better results. By utilizing a ring light or Elgato Key Light, and ensuring that there are no windows to your side or rear, you'll create a more even picture with fewer shadows. For more, read [5 tips for mastering video calls on the GitLab blog](#).

## Headphones

Wearing headphones, particularly in noisy environments, creates a more positive audio experience for all. Your choice of headphone will vary depending on your workspace. For example, if you're using a dedicated microphone, you may prefer comfortable studio-style headphones without an in-line mic. If you want to reduce the amount of hardware you're using, headphones with an in-line mic will be more appropriate.

GitLab recommends trying out various headphone styles in advance if possible. Open-ear vs. closed-ear, for example, provides a very different listening experience. Noise-cancelling headphones are great for crowded coworking spaces, but may blot out too much sound for work-from-home caregivers who need to be aware of what's happening inside the home.

It's important to consider long-term comfort for those who may find themselves in video calls for multiple hours per day. For example, some people prefer in-ear headphones rather than over-the-head headphones.

Bluetooth headphones can be problematic for roles requiring a significant amount of calls, due to limitations of microphone quality, latency, and battery life. If you opt for Bluetooth headphones, you may want to also use a separate wired microphone. Bluetooth headphones, if paired with multiple devices (e.g. one pair of headphones with a pairing history involving a laptop as well as a phone), may jump between devices. We recommend pairing one set of Bluetooth headphones per device to avoid unexpected disconnects during video calls.

What constitutes "good headphones" varies significantly depending on preference. We recommend digging into Wirecutter's various headphone guides for researched suggestions.

## Microphone

Almost any phone or laptop comes with a built-in microphone that should be adequate for your needs. A pair of Bluetooth or wired earbuds with an in-line microphone can help reduce background noise, if you work in a noisy space. These are commonly included with most smartphones.

However, if you frequently speak in front of audiences, record talks or podcasts, or simply

wish to have excellent audio quality, invest in a dedicated USB microphone (and, if desired, a desk mount for added ergonomic positioning). For example, Blue Microphones offers a variety of options that are crafted with creators, streamers, and podcasters in mind, and all provide exceptional clarity and noise reduction on video calls. Another great option is the 512 Tempest.

"When audio quality is high (vs low), people judge the content as better and more important. They also judge the speaker as more intelligent, competent, and likable. Messages that are difficult to process are less compelling." This research, conducted by Norbert Schwarz at the University of Southern California, reinforces the importance of investing in equipment and atmosphere to generate the highest-fidelity audio in a remote work setting. If you have the funds available, this is an often-overlooked but very worthy way to use them.

## Monitor

If you feel that your digital workspace is too cramped when relying solely on a laptop, consider using at least one external monitor. External monitors offer flexible positioning, which allows your neck to be situated in a more natural and ergonomically correct position.

If you do video calls often, an external display will enable you to use one screen for video chatting and another for documentation, referencing pages, etc.

If you feel overwhelmed by too much information spread across multiple monitors, consider window management software solutions such as Rectangle and Magnet.

If you'd like a portable monitor and you primarily use a MacBook laptop, consider expanding your visual workspace with Sidecar (available in macOS Catalina). This allows an iPad to double as a secondary display for your Mac.

## Teleprompter

If you present content regularly, consider adding a teleprompter that enables you to read a pre-written script while looking directly into a lens. This straight-on profile creates a more authentic connection with the audience, akin to a newscaster on television, especially when creating training modules or asynchronous video overviews.

### Why teleprompters aren't ideal for everyday video calls

Teleprompters enable eye contact similar to meeting someone in-person and can make meetings more engaging. However, there are currently challenges with using a teleprompter setup as your everyday video conferencing setup. Once these are overcome, we may recommend it.

1. Problem (Major): When Zoom is on the teleprompter, the chat, controls, and screen sharing are extremely small and unusable. They have a "dual monitor" mode that is meant for screen sharing and it behaves as expected for n=3+ calls. But for 1:1 calls it unexpectedly puts yourself on the video window in the teleprompter.

- Mitigation: We may need to wait for Zoom to roll out a new mode that is teleprompter-specific

1. Problem (Major): The mouse, Zoom controls, and screen shared content are horizontally flipped on the teleprompter making it very difficult to work

- Mitigation: Buy a device that horizontally flips the HDMI output to the monitor mounted in the teleprompter

1. Problem (Minor): It's disconcerting that the audio of the person you're looking at is coming from your computer which is sitting to the side. This is especially true when you have a video monitor window on that computer that pulls your attention away from the teleprompter because it's brighter, larger, and syncs to the audio

- Mitigation: External stereo speakers that mount to teleprompter

1. Problem (Minor): It's harder to know when your camera is off when it's mounted in a teleprompter. And that's a problem if your office is a guest bedroom (or something)

- Mitigations

- Get some sort of "on air" light

- Get a black silk hood to flip over the camera

- Remember to turn the camera off every single time

1. Problem (Minor): The video quality is slightly degraded by the physics of light passing through an additional pane of glass

- Mitigations

- Adjust lighting

- Just live with the difference (not that bad)

## External keyboard and mouse

Laptop keyboards are engineered to fit the laptop, not to be ergonomic. Whenever possible, consider working in a space where there's room to utilize an external keyboard. This allows you to adjust the keyboard so that you're typing in a natural way, reducing strain on your wrists and fingers.

There are a wide variety of ergonomic keyboards, and it's worth trying out a few in a retail location if possible. If this is not practical, Wirecutter has assembled a well-researched guide on the best ergonomic keyboards.

A traditional mouse can put strain on the wrist by creating movements in an unnatural position. Fortunately there are plenty of other options available such as vertical mice, trackpads, trackballs and pen tablets. Each has their own advantages. Find one that is comfortable for you and minimizes wrist movement as much as possible (vertical mice, for example, engage your shoulder and arm more than your wrist and trackballs rely on moving your fingers). You can also consider a left-handed mouse. Wirecutter and CNN Underscored both recommend the Logitech MX Master 3 mouse. See CNN Underscored for a list of other recommended ergonomic mice [here](#).

It's important for remote workers to be cognizant of repetitive motion. While it may seem extreme to some, consider installing two mice and switching hands to move one's cursor.

## What furniture should I use in my home office?

Keep in mind that work often happens in multiple spaces throughout the workweek. You'll want to consider a range of spaces for different types of work:

1. Primary spaces: Ideal for deep, focused work where you need secondary screens, specialized tools, or controlled conditions for important video calls.

1. Secondary spaces: Try these for re-energizing your mind with coffee chats, 1:1s, learning and development, etc.

1. On-the-go spaces: Great for cognitively light work and fitting in bursts of productivity between meetings or appointments.

## Chair

Seating should be not viewed as an expense, but as an investment in your health, comfort, and productivity.

Unless you plan to utilize a standing desk, which is covered below, your chair is likely to be the single most important element of your home office. Not all ergonomic chairs are created equal, and a chair that works well for one person may not be ideal for another. It's important to consider your posture, and make adjustments to habits if needed, to make the most of an ergonomic chair.

Many remote workers spend a significant portion of their day seated. While resources exist to explain how frequently you should take a break, stand up, stretch, and engage in activity during the workday, you should be careful not to skimp on seating.

If possible, visit a physical store to try out a variety of ergonomic seating options, or purchase online from a retailer that offers a generous return policy.

Steelcase and MillerKnoll both offer solid options. While retail pricing on chairs from these firms is very high, you can often find them used for less. To assist in your research, consider Wirecutter's exhaustive (and continually updated) guide to office chairs.

Employers: Consider offering an allowance for employees to invest in a high-quality ergonomic chair.

## Desk

While some remote workers prefer to bounce around during the day, those looking to invest in a desk for a dedicated workspace should consider a few elements.

- Plan your desk purchase to fit your equipment, rather than the other way around.
- If you plan to use one or more desktop monitors (which is recommended), measure the physical dimensions and ensure that your desk has room to hold them.
- Factor in other items such as external speakers, scanners, printers, microphone mounts, webcams, external webcam lighting, etc.

Generally, a larger desk is preferred, as it reduces crowding. A clean, uncrowded desk is a happier place to work from.

## Standing desks

An adjustable standing desk is a great, ergonomic option. You can find standing desks at a variety of price points, heights, adjustability levels, and more. An adjustable desk allows you to easily move your desk higher in order to stand while working, and then adjust it back down to sit for a time. This is a good article on The Best Standing Desks in higher price ranges.

GitLab team members have been satisfied with the value and quality of standing desks from

Autonomous, IKEA, Fully and WorkTrainer for small spaces.

Research is ongoing as to the ideal ratio of sitting to standing during a workday.

> Using advanced ergonomic and health risk calculations, Jack Callaghan, a professor in Waterloo's Department of Kinesiology, has found that the ideal sit-stand ratio lies somewhere between 1:1 and 1:3 · a vast departure from traditional wisdom.

### Standing mats

If you plan to stand for an extended portion of your working day, consider investing in a standing desk mat. Also called anti-fatigue mats, these cushion one's feet and allow natural weight shifting while working.

### Office supplies

If you're transitioning from an office environment where supplies magically appeared or were stocked in a closet for your use, now you are responsible for acquiring them. Check out our complete list of office supplies.

### Creating the right environment

#### Lighting

When communicating via webcam, you need to be aware of your lighting scheme.

Meetings are about the work, not the background, but those who are designing their home office may want to consider lighting before too many absolutes are put in place. Here are a few lighting tips to be mindful of.

1. Avoid backlighting or sidelighting when possible (e.g. design your office so that outside light shines onto your face, not your back or side).
1. Consider smart bulbs (e.g. Philips Hue) to light your office, which can be tweaked to create a soft, pleasing light regardless of your wall color.
1. While enclosed rooms are ideal for controlling light, they may feel inhibiting to work from.
1. Try to avoid shadows and changing light conditions.

While studio lighting is ideal, not everyone will be inclined to install large, heat-generating light boxes in their home office. As remote work and live-streaming become more popular, companies are devising smaller solutions. Elgato's Key Light is a great example. By placing one Key Light at the edge of a desk and facing its LEDs directly into the wall, a soft, refreshing light is bounced back onto the participant.

DIY solutions are relatively easy to create with a mount and a light ring.

Aside from your video setup, lighting is also an important factor in your overall comfort and productivity in your office space. Natural light is best, particularly when your desk is facing the light source to help avoid glare. If you don't have access to natural light, consider using adjustable bulbs to mimic natural lighting.

## Atmosphere

If you've learned to be productive in a conventional open office floor plan, you'll likely be able to increase your productivity level as a remote team member.

Consider where you prefer to work on a daily basis and optimize this space for focus. Try to remove visual, sound, and motion distractions to maximize your focus on work while in the space and healthily disconnect when you exit.

## Busy/available indicators

While remote workers should relish the benefits of being close to friends and family while working, some may prefer a more formal approach to signaling their availability.

For example, the Luxafor Flag light indicator utilizes a color system to alert those around you (or outside of your home office) whether or not they are free to interrupt without requesting permission.

Alternatively, if you have access to a nearby light fixture, install a color-changing smart bulb connected to your phone or computer to change the color to indicate availability.

## Ergonomics

Remote employees may want to consider hiring a trained ergonomic consultant to provide professional input and recommendations on how your home office should be constructed. While this is an investment, it's the type of cost that can be significantly offset over time by improving your health and well-being.

## Finding the ideal temperature

Research has found that there is no single temperature in which all people are more productive. Consider testing several temperatures to see which suits you, or adjust temperature based on your work activity.

## Examples of work-from-home setups

- GitLab Head of Remote, Darren M., shares details on his work-from-home arrangement, which includes a mirrorless camera as a webcam for optimal video quality.
- Job van der Voort, CEO at Remote, provides a breakdown of his top-notch home office setup.
- GitLab Developer Advocate Michael F. details his current setup with helpful tips on lighting, apps and settings, and how to personalize your workspace.
- Emma Bostian, Software Engineer at Spotify, writes about her home-office tech setup for recording courses and podcasts
- Andreas Klinger, founder at Remote First Capital, maintains an ongoing Twitter thread of exceptional at-home workspaces.

What are some tips for creating a productive home office?

Set up work-life boundaries

Plan your work time and time off in advance. When you're not working, turn off Slack and close your email client. At GitLab, this only works if all team members abide by the communication guidelines. It also helps to enable the "working hours" feature on your calendar so that team members in other time zones know when to schedule meetings.

Have an open, honest conversation with co-dwellers about your working hours. Explain that while you are home, you should be considered unreachable unless there's a significant level of need.

Be sure to have the "I'm home but working" conversation with children, who may struggle to understand why a working parent is in the home but unable or unwilling to engage with them for certain parts of the day.

How can I decorate my home office?

When you work from home, you create a space that fuels your work. According to this Thrive Global article on remote space setup, "Maybe that is art, pictures, having a couch close by, or maybe it's just having music playing...at home you can really do whatever you want. It feels less like a corporate job and more of your own thing."

Try not to worry about your background too much. Sometimes pets or family wander into a room while you're on a call and reminds us that we are people first and colleagues second.

Not sure what is reimbursable?

Items you want for your home office may or may not be reimbursable. Please refer to the Home Office Equipment and Supplies to see what is allowed to be reimbursed.

What should I do if I don't have enough space for a home office?

Get creative if you cannot dedicate space for a permanent home office. You can assemble movable pieces for a "mobile office" that you set up and tear down daily, utilize a co-working space, work from a public business or building, or tether to work anywhere. Our team members have entertaining stories of getting creative to connect, everything from working in parked vehicles to access public wi-fi to SIM cards and tethering devices allowing connection from an exotic mountaintop.

Leadership's role in supporting healthy workspaces

Whether an organization is fully remote, remote-first, or hybrid, it's up to company leaders to enable an equitable and inclusive employee experience. Just as you'd invest in a team's workspace in a physical office, enabling team members to create healthy and productive spaces is a core part of building remote infrastructure. An optimized workspace leads to team member happiness, wellness, and engagement, and it also leads to better overall results for your organization.

Keep in mind that there's no "one size fits all" for a home office setup, because each member of your team has different needs, work preferences, and home environments. Consider providing budget for your team to spend on their home workspace, a coworking space, or equipment needed to be productive on the go. For example, at GitLab, team members are allowed to spend company money as they would their own, with guidance provided for various types of equipment. Keep in



mind that team members' needs may change as they experiment to find their ideal work environment.

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Considerations for a productive home office or remote workspace

Anyone can test their knowledge on how to set up a productive home office or remote workspace by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, reach out to our Learning & Development team at [learning@gitlab.com](mailto:learning@gitlab.com).

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{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}
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Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

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Return to the main all-remote page.

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## SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/collaboration-and-whiteboarding/\_index.md

On this page, we're detailing how collaboration and whiteboarding works in a global all-remote company.

How do you collaborate and whiteboard in an all-remote environment?

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"How do you collaborate and whiteboard in a remote environment?" is a frequently asked question. In a colocated setting, collaboration often happens face-to-face with a whiteboard on hand in a conference room. Working remotely sometimes feels like working on your own, with your own calendar, and your own schedule. With a common goal, strategic planning, and the right collaboration tools, working in a remote environment can be even more productive than working in an office.

How virtual whiteboard collaboration supports remote teams

For deep-dives on how GitLab's UX and design teams collaborate remotely, visit the UX Team Playlist on GitLab Unfiltered and read the series of GitLab blog posts below.

1. Designing in an all-remote company

1. Improving iteration and collaboration with user stories
1. Running an asynchronous sketch workshop for UX
1. Synchronous collaboration as a remote designer at GitLab

What are the best online whiteboards with collaboration features?

When looking for the right tool for you and your team, consider what's most important:

- people--allows your team to collaborate equally despite time zones, technology platforms etc.
- principles--supports the core vision and operating principles of your company
- process--smooth and efficient workflows
- product--achieves the outcome/s needed

Does Google have a collaborative whiteboard?

Remote teams should aim to minimize their tool stack. It's good practice to consider how you can extract additional value from tools you already use, and Google Docs is a great example of this. While Google Docs is a fantastic shared editing tool, GitLab also uses it for temporal meeting documentation (prior to contextualizing takeaways for placement in relevant handbook sections).

It also happens to be a great remote whiteboarding tool.

Advantages of Google Docs with numbered lists and indentation

1. Everyone can write, not just the most senior people in the room
1. Multiple people can write at the same time, allowing purer trains of thought to reach canvas versus waiting your turn
1. Can see what people are looking at in real-time via cursor indicators
1. Can make suggestions
1. Can make low-context comments that are time-stamped
1. Can change hierarchy with indentation
1. Can copy and paste
1. Doesn't run out of space
1. Doesn't need to be deleted after the meeting
1. Can be iterated on prior to a meeting
1. Can be iterated on after a meeting ends
1. Inline with agenda/notes of meeting
1. Font is more readable than handwriting
1. Can use URLs to link to external resources
1. Can add screenshots and embeds from other tools and platforms to visualize thoughts
1. The Google Doc itself becomes an artifact that can be linked to or embedded in other tools and platforms
1. The Google Doc can be shared globally with a link for feedback from the entire world, if so desired

Whiteboarding Applications

When a text-based document is too limited, try a collaborative, visual-oriented tool.

MURAL is the number one sketch tool used by product designers. Mural comes preloaded with a ton of templates. It takes skill and a willingness to experiment to start to utilize them in productive ways, but it is encouraged by PMs at GitLab. The UX Research and Product Design rooms in Mural have several examples of designers doing all sorts of amazing work in Mural.

Google JamBoard is free, has a native application for mobile platforms and easily imports Google Slides for further animation.

Miro has extensive conversion of pen strokes to graphics objects and real text and it includes many templates and team sharing capabilities.

Contributed all-remote whiteboard setups

## 1. Inexpensive Active Pen Tablet Setup and Three Whiteboarding Apps

How do I run a virtual whiteboard session?

Once you've decided which tool is best for you, here are a few tips for running a successful whiteboard session:

1. Define goals for the session
1. Set a defined amount of time for the session in general and each activity specifically
1. Start with a clean slate
1. Explain how the system works and how each member is expected to participate and contribute
1. Assign someone to keep the whiteboard organized
1. Assign deliverables and tasks

Getting started with all-remote collaboration

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Do not fixate on the medium; instead, fixate on the outcome. Instead of attempting to create a virtual whiteboard, focus on what outcomes you typically expect from a whiteboarding session. In a remote setting, a team must be intentional about everything, including a fixation on results. This requires a change of mentality.

Learn more about "the whiteboarding fixation" in our guide to understanding the phases of remote adaptation.

People planning

{{< youtube "xt5cxXBv1-A" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, GitLab Head of Remote Darren M. discusses remote team collaboration with Till P. creator of remote collaboration platform CoScreen.

Remote collaboration starts with people. Creating a remote culture includes trusting that the people within the company will do their work. Documentation is vital to the independence of employees. This includes documenting everything from company values to daily meetings.

Tools and technology will enable a company to operate efficiently, but ensuring that there is documentation with core standards is the first step in setting a collaborative remote environment.

Remote collaboration requires an alignment of principles and values as a baseline for stakeholders. Creating mental methods, or frameworks, for collaborators sets a clear roadmap for expectations, ethics, and goals.

> "Without the principles and an understanding of which decision-making framework to use and when, people could apply the wrong tool to the job," · Mike Long, UX Manager, GitLab

Collaborative whiteboarding supports diversity, inclusion and belonging

Collaborative whiteboarding has positive impacts to diversity, inclusion and belonging by:

- providing substantially better shared understanding when presenter and participants do not share a common spoken language.
- assisting with neurodiversity through multi-sensory collaboration.
- improving comprehension regardless of natural differences between individuals in conceptualizing non-visual information.

Collaborating through text

The most important aspect of collaboration meetings is to have an agenda. Creating an agenda helps to cover everything and sets a plan for the scheduled discussion. It also makes it easier for those who didn't attend to feel included by having a document they can review after the meeting. Not everyone will always be in the meeting, but they can stay up-to-date as long as the meeting is documented, encouraging clear communication. Google Docs is a collaborative, real-time tool to take notes, share decisions, and keep all stakeholders informed.

Most design discussions and decisions at GitLab are created and worked in GitLab Issues. Recently, Design Management was released in order for designers to upload images and make comments in the same platform that Product Managers and Developers use.

> "The most important thing to remember when designing remotely is: document, document, document," · Christie Lenneville, Director of UX, GitLab

Company handbook

At GitLab, we believe that "everyone can contribute." The company handbook is where everything is documented · our single source of truth · specifically laying out the six core values of the company. The handbook deliberately and intentionally describes each group's role within the company, including how the UX teams researches, designs and writes about the product.

Iterate and iterate some more

Since the inception of GitLab, iteration has been one of six core values and steers the creation of product development. Making many small changes has been a way to make improvements faster.

> "To a UX researcher iteration means something different to me than other people. The value of iteration should encourage people to change directions when they find answers to their questions. Iteration should be a stop-gap measure to say 'This is not the right solution. We will stop and reassess and rethink what is the right solution to this problem.'" · Lorie Whitaker, Senior UX Researcher, GitLab

### Zoom for all

Any meeting at GitLab happens over a Zoom call. Face to face is the best way to "meet" someone in person. On top of that, press record to digitally document the meeting for future reference or for anyone who might not make the call. Zoom also has a whiteboard function in Zoom Rooms for Touch. Attendees can access and annotate a whiteboard on the call and then save and share the whiteboard by email.

### Pinging on Slack

Slack is generally accepted as an informal method of communication. Slack channels can be created easily for various groups or individuals. If there are questions or comments that require a quick response, Slack is the best way to get in touch with a co-worker. Slack is a fast way to collaborate on a topic without having to schedule a meeting in advance.

> "Pinging someone on slack is like bumping into them in the hallway," · Alexis Ginsberg, Senior Product Designer at GitLab

### Synchronous collaboration

Synchronous work within a standard organization makes sense. Work starts and ends when people enter and leave the office. Meetings happen all together in some version of a boardroom. However, when co-workers are spread throughout the world, sync collaboration can be a bit more challenging. Here are some ways that GitLab has been able to establish a level of normalcy regardless of what time zone people are in.

### Meeting in pairs

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Schedule meetings with a co-worker. Meeting in pairs allows for some serious one-on-one face time to collaborate on challenges and goals. This time permits each attendee to share what they're working on and potentially share projects that they might not be familiar with. With Zoom, the screen sharing option lets you get hands on with your meeting partner's work.

At GitLab, the Pair Design program was launched to connect a product designer with a design peer who is within the same time zone, but works on a different part of the product. Each pair meets for six months and then they are swapped out to give everyone exposure to different ideas, product areas, and collaborations.

> "I have loved working with each of my 'pairs' in UX! Usually we meet once a week for 30 minutes to an hour and spend about half the time each talking about something that is top of mind for us.

>

> Sometimes it is just discussing some process or higher level stuff; most of the time we are sharing our screens in Zoom and walking through Sketch, Figma, Axure, someone's branch, etc. to talk through design challenges we are having.

>

> The most exciting part of this to me is getting to really dive into a space that I don't get as much exposure to · also getting to know another designer and having that dedicated time just for us." · Alexis Ginsberg, Senior Product Designer at GitLab

### Group syncs

Meet with your group to get a better idea of what everyone is working on, where the status of a project is, and get a general sense of who you're working with. At GitLab, the plan designers have a dedicated time to meet and discuss what they are working on and are able to collaborate on anything they want feedback on. Some projects overlap, so this is especially helpful for all involved to stay in sync. Team members appreciate having these designer syncs on some cadence where it feels less formal (more like huddling at a desk together looking at designs) than scheduling time ad hoc.

### PM and Design hangout

Every week the Plan designs and Plan PMs meet and discuss research in-flight or any work that needs collaboration. They also discuss priorities and walk the board if there is time (this is the least important item as we have other touch points for this). The critical part of this call is discussing the goals for the week. It is another way to learn what everyone is working on · both personally and professionally.

### Social hours

Create a social hour where everyone is welcome to join to chat or play games together. Try two social hours every other week with the purpose of capturing enough time zones so that teammates can be "in-person." This isn't exactly "work" collaboration related, but creates a bond with teammates in order to feel more comfortable together and therefore more effective and excited to collaborate.

### Asynchronous collaboration

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Asynchronous communication is the process of being productive without depending on the presence of other people. Async work empowers people to work independently and to trust that others are doing the same, but not necessarily at the same time. Collaborating asynchronously frees people from calendars and time zones.

With documentation, there is transparency on workloads, project capacity, and an overall understanding of what everyone's expectations are. The focus shifts away from the hours spent doing the work, to the actual results of the work.

### Digital documentation

Digitally documented design with videos is a helpful way to keep the creative education flowing. It is also another way to keep team members up-to-date with new and upcoming projects, design ideas, and trends.

> "In these videos, we lay out the rationale behind our designs and also offer information about other options we thought about and decided against. In certain situations, it also makes sense to add additional background about our long-term vision.

>

> One of the many positive outcomes from this approach is that even team members who have only been minimally involved are now empowered to provide feedback, add their own ideas, or provide us with additional information about the amount of work our ideas will require." · Christie Lenneville, Director of UX, GitLab

### Sketch workshops

At GitLab, Async sketch workshops are another way to collaborate with peers. The process is similar to an in-person whiteboard workshop, only collaborators are using Mural instead. Guidelines are set for individual workshops, leaders are in place, and contributors have a general familiarity with the product.

### GitLab Issues and merge requests (MR)

GitLab's policy is to dogfood everything. Issues and merge requests are where the majority of collaboration occur. GitLab design issues are works in progress, feedback is welcome and expected, and everyone is encouraged to contribute. The platform's transparency helps remote teams interface to produce better products faster.

> "I really enjoy reviewing MRs and being able to check out branches on my own instead of relying on others to walk me through things at their desk or sending me to an app like I may have had to do in the past. I can be reviewing something for someone while they sleep...it feels like we are better able to support and collaborate with each other and work on efforts together." · Alexis Ginsberg, Senior Product Designer, GitLab

### GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Remote collaboration and whiteboarding

Complete all knowledge assessments in the Remote Work Foundation certification to receive the Remote Foundations Badge in GitLab Learn. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at [learning@gitlab.com](mailto:learning@gitlab.com).

```
{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}
```

### Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

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Return to the main all-remote page.

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## SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/collaboration-and-whiteboarding/setups.md

Importance of Flow When Whiteboarding Technical Explanations or Collaborations

Virtual Whiteboarding is a Remote Work Super Power for Technical Explanation and Collaboration

Doubled down usage for in-person and hybrid meetings as well

All-remote whiteboard setups also work well when leveraged for in-person and hybrid meetings because:

- They eliminate the organizational logistics for the meeting room to have a physical whiteboard and enables whiteboarding when the need was not foreseen.
- When in-person meetings have remote participants, the remote participants can be fully accommodated by the same screen share being used in the meeting room.

Samsung Active Pen Tablet with LiveBoard App

This setup was devised by checking out many Tablet types (e.g. non-active pen ones), Apps and Websites.

The emphasis for selection was prioritized on:

- Fluidity of drawing experience.
- Speed of rendering in co-joined Zoom laptop.
- Avoiding requiring participants to each join the whiteboard site just to view (because a lot of sessions won't require collaborative contributions). However, also retain the option for other participants to join quickly to contribute when it is desirable - without cost and hopefully without a registration.
- Keeping cost low to make the solution more accessible to more people. (ended up at USD \$265 at time of acquisition)

The first three criteria drove a lot of research into many applications + collaborative sites. Notably, options that did not support a native mobile application (used a webpage) lacked drawing fluidity.

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Components

- Drawing Surface Option 1: Samsung Galaxy Tab A 8.0 with Spen (SM-P200) \$235.
  - Large enough, but reasonably portable.
  - Doubles as an ebook reader.
  - Active pen technology is critical to fluidity.
  - Battery life is great.



- Drawing Surface Option 2: Samsung Galaxy Tab S6 Lite 10.4" with Spen (SM-P610NZBAXAR) \$300.
- Larger screen for easier drawing
- The Drawing Implement: Staedtler Digital Pencil \$30 - the built in stylus is too small for drawing speed.
- The Collaborative Whiteboard App: LiveBoard.online Apps / Website, Free Forever attributes:

|                                                   | Liveboard Online      | Google Jamboard | Miro |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------|------|
| Long Term Usage of Free Tier                      | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | No                    |                 |      |
| Native Mobile Apps                                | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Native Desktop Apps                               | No                    |                 |      |
| No                                                | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Web App (For Screen Sharing)                      | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Fluidity Extras                                   |                       |                 |      |
|                                                   | Multiple pens on deck |                 |      |
| Pages / Canvas                                    | Pages                 |                 |      |
| Pages                                             | Endless Canvas        |                 |      |
| Presentation Mode                                 | No                    |                 |      |
| No                                                | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Direct Import From Google Slides                  | No                    |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | No                    |                 |      |
| Shape Recognition from Hand Drawing               | Light Duty            |                 |      |
| Light Duty                                        | Awesome               |                 |      |
| Export to PDF                                     | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | No                    |                 |      |
| Reusability of Drawing as Formal Technical Design | No                    |                 |      |
| No                                                | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Viewers Synchronized to Drawing Location          | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | Manual                |                 |      |
| Simple UI for Drawing                             | Yes                   |                 |      |
| Yes                                               | No                    |                 |      |

## Using This Setup

### Liveboard

1. Create two free accounts on <https://www.liveboard.online/>.
1. On your mobile app, create a "session" and invite the second user.
1. On your zoom laptop, join as the second user. (it is important that the user owning the whiteboard session be logged in on the tablet so that the "new page" control resides there.)
1. Screen share the whiteboard from the laptop web logon - since in most cases others won't contribute.
1. Be ready to share a link if others desire to contribute (req \$5/mon to have guests which do not have to register to participate).

## Android Settings

Android tablets with no physical buttons put a navigation bar on the bottom part of the screen. I found that I was having my palm be picked up by the Home Screen button, which would close the white boarding app. Also, when any of these buttons are activated by the stylus it is equally disruptive to the flow. For the Navigation Bar settings I set "Navigation type" to "Swipe gestures" and I enable "Block gestures with S Pen" (Android 12, Samsung OneUI v4.1)

## Questions About This Setup

This setup is the result of Darwin Sanoy thinking about the problem way too much ;)

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## SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/guide/\_index.md

GitLab is one of the world's largest all-remote companies with over 1,500 team members located in more than 65 countries around the world.

Our all-remote workforce implementation is featured in The Journal of Organizational Design. It is also the centerpiece of case studies authored by Harvard Business School and INSEAD.

On this page and subpages, we'll share what "all-remote" really means, how it works at GitLab, some tips and tricks for remote teams, and resources to learn more.

## The Remote Manifesto

All-remote work promotes:

1. Hiring and working from all over the world (instead of from a central location).
1. Flexible working hours (over set working hours).
1. Writing down and recording knowledge (over verbal explanations).
1. Written processes (over on-the-job training).
1. Public sharing of information (over need-to-know access).
1. Opening up documents for editing by anyone (over top-down control of documents).
1. Asynchronous communication (over synchronous communication).
1. The results of impact (over the activity put in).
1. Formal communication channels (over informal communication channels).

## Why remote?

{{< youtube "GKMUs7WXm-E" >}}

> "Remote is not a challenge to overcome. It's a clear business advantage." -Victor, Product Manager, GitLab

From the cost savings on office space to more flexibility in employees' daily lives, all-remote work offers a number of advantages to organizations and their people.

But we also recognize that being part of an all-remote company isn't for everyone. Here's a

look at some of the advantages and disadvantages.

### Our long-term vision for remote work

Learn more about GitLab's long-term vision for remote work, and why we can embrace the future of work right now.

### Why GitLab uses the term all-remote to describe its 100% remote workforce

All-remote means that each individual in an organization is empowered to work and live where they are most fulfilled. By including the word "all" in "all-remote," it makes clear that every team member is equal. No one, not even the executive team, meets in-person on a daily basis.

Learn more about why GitLab uses the term all-remote to describe its 100% remote workforce.

### The Remote Work Report by GitLab

Created to foster collaboration, innovation, and evolution in the future of work, the 2020 Global Remote Work Report dissects the state of distributed work and surfaces key motivators for both employees and employers.

Download the full report now.

### Why GitLab uses GitLab for remote collaboration

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at GitLab's remote team solutions page.

### How we built our all-remote team

As GitLab has grown, we've learned a lot about what it takes to build and manage a fully remote team, and want to share this knowledge to help others be successful.

Find out how GitLab makes it work.

### Advantages and benefits

Operating in an all-remote environment provides a multitude of benefits and competitive advantages for employees, employers, and the world.

Learn more about benefits and advantages to operating in an all-remote environment.

### Disadvantages

Despite its many advantages, all-remote work isn't for everyone. It can have disadvantages for

potential employees depending on their lifestyle and work preferences, as well as the organization.

Learn more about disadvantages to all-remote, along with solutions to these challenges.

### The GitLab Test: 12 Steps to Better Remote

Borrowing format from The Joel Test, this 12 question test helps leaders understand if you're running a great remote operation.

### Remote work emergency plan: What to do (and where to start)

Due to global issues concerning COVID-19 (Coronavirus), many employees and employers are facing a new reality: they're remote, and they're unsure of when they'll be able to return to the office.

For leaders who are suddenly managing work-from-home teams, here are five things you can focus on right now to maximize stability.

### Remote work starter guide: how to adjust to work-from-home

For employees who are grappling with a new remote reality (or forced work-from-home), here are five tips to implement straight away in your journey to acclimate.

### The phases of remote adaptation

As teams grapple with transitioning from a colocated environment to a remote one, it's common to see differing levels of adaptability.

Learn more about the phases of remote adaptation.

### GitLab pioneers the 'Head of Remote' role

By hiring a Head of Remote in 2019, GitLab triggered a global movement of appointing a dedicated leader to evolve a company's remote fluency.

This page details the backstory of the movement's origins, explains what a Head of Remote is, provides job description templates, and open source certifications to enhance your markability as a remote work leader.

### Being a great remote manager

Many traits found in superb remote managers are also found in managers of colocated teams, though there are nuances to serving, leading, and guiding when managing teams that you do not see in-person each day.

Learn what it takes to be a great remote manager.

### People

All-remote organizations tend to attract people who place a high degree of value on autonomy, flexibility, empathy, and mobility. It also presents outsized opportunity for people who must live or prefer to live in rural areas, where well-paying careers in technical industries are few and far between.

Learn more about the types of people who are adopting a remote lifestyle.

### Non-linear workday

How diverse, invigorating, gratifying, and productive could your day be if you threw away the notion that you had to stick to a daily routine?

Learn more about what life can look and feel like when embracing a non-linear workday.

### Values

While all-remote isn't a value itself, it's something we do in order to practice our values.

Learn how a collection of values at GitLab contributes to a thriving all-remote environment.

### Building and reinforcing a sustainable culture

Culture is best defined not by how a company or team acts when all is well; rather, by the behaviors shown during times of crisis or duress.

Learn more about creating a thriving, lasting remote culture.

### Combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety

Mental health is an important topic for all companies, and creating a healthy remote workplace is essential to business success.

Learn more about combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety in the remote workplace.

### Jobs

Job seekers are wise to point their efforts towards companies that are built to support 100% remote. You're able to bypass hours of lobbying for a remote arrangement during the interview process, and you're assured that the tools you need to operate effectively from anywhere will be included from the get-go.

Learn more about all-remote and remote-first organizations leading the way, job boards that curate high-quality remote roles, and informal job searching tactics.

### How to evaluate a remote role

Not every remote job is created equal. Learn more about considerations and questions to ask when evaluating a remote role.

### Getting started in a remote role

Learn more about considerations and tips for starting a new remote role.

## Management

Managing an all-remote company is much like managing any other company. It comes down to trust, communication, and company-wide support of shared goals.

Learn more about what's required to effectively and efficiently manage an all-remote company.

## Forcing functions to work remote-first

Whether it's unwinding from offices entirely and going all-remote, or attempting to create a level playing field for in-office and remote team members in a hybrid-remote arrangement, leaders should consider key forcing functions to ensure a commitment to remote-first practices.

Learn more about tactical, actionable steps that will send a clear message that leadership is serious about implementing remote in the organization.

## Collaboration and whiteboarding with remote teams

"How do you collaborate and whiteboard in a remote environment?" is a frequently asked question. In a colocated setting, collaboration often happens face-to-face with a whiteboard on hand in a conference room. Working remotely sometimes feels like working on your own, with your own calendar, and your own schedule. With a common goal, strategic planning, and the right collaboration tools, working in a remote environment can be even more productive than working in an office.

Learn more about collaboration and whiteboarding in remote work environments.

## Remote onboarding

Onboarding remotely should focus on three key dimensions: the organizational, the technical, and the social. By using this integrated approach, top companies enable their employees to stay and thrive in their roles. We'll show how you can focus on these three key dimensions of onboarding through an all-remote onboarding process.

Learn more in GitLab's guide to remote onboarding.

## Scaling

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and that it not only works well at scale, but works better at scale than antiquated colocated models.

Learn more about challenges, solutions, and benefits of all-remote at scale.

## Stages of remote work

Learn more about the various stages of remote work, from no remote to all-remote.

## Tips for working remotely

Building a remote team or starting your first all-remote job? Check out our tips for working remotely.

## Resources

Browse our resources page to learn more about GitLab's approach, read about remote work in the news, and see what other companies are leading the way.

We've also compiled a list of companies that have been inspired by GitLab's culture.

## Hiring

GitLab envisions a world where talented, driven individuals can find roles and seek employment based on business needs, rather than an oftentimes arbitrary location.

Hiring across the globe isn't without its challenges. There are local regulations and risks unique to countries and regions around the globe. We believe that these challenges are worth overcoming, and opening our talent acquisition pipeline beyond the usual job centers creates a competitive advantage. We hope to see this advantage wane as more all-remote companies are created.

Learn more about hiring in an all-remote environment.

## Compensation

While there are certain complexities to paying team members who are spread out in over 50 countries, we believe that it's worthwhile. Being an all-remote company enables us to hire the world's best talent, not just the best talent from a few cities.

Learn more about compensation in an all-remote environment.

## Learning and Development

We believe that all-remote companies are at a competitive advantage when it comes to educating and developing team members.

Learn more on how to make learning and development a company-wide mindset in an all-remote environment.

## Self-service

It's not what you know. It's knowing where to look. This is true at GitLab and other organizations that are intentional about documenting processes, and it is entirely counter to how typical work environments are structured.

Learn more about the importance of self-searching, self-learning, and self-service in an all-remote organization.

## Informal Communication

In an all-remote environment, informal communication should be formally addressed. Leaders should organize informal communication, and to whatever degree possible, design an atmosphere where team members all over the globe feel comfortable reaching out to anyone to converse about topics unrelated to work.

Learn more about enabling informal communication in an all-remote company.

### Asynchronous communication

In an all-remote setting, where team members are empowered to live and work where they're most fulfilled, mastering asynchronous workflows is vital to avoiding dysfunction and enjoying outsized efficiencies. Increasingly, operating asynchronously is necessary even in colocated companies which have team members on various floors or offices, especially when multiple time zones are involved.

Learn more about implementing asynchronous workflows in your organization, and the benefits to both employee and employer.

### Handbook-first documentation

A handbook-first organization is home to team members who benefit from having a single source of truth to lean on. This type of organization is able to operate with almost supernatural efficiency. An organization that does not put concerted effort into documenting has no choice but to watch its team members ask and re-ask for same bits of data in perpetuity, creating a torturous loop of interruptions, meetings, and suboptimal knowledge transfers.

Learn more about the significance of handbook-first documentation.

### Meetings

Learn how to decide when a meeting is necessary and how to optimize them in an all-remote environment.

### Communicating effectively and responsibly through text

Embracing text communication and learning to use it effectively requires a mental shift. This can feel unusual or even uncomfortable for those who come from a colocated environment, where in-person meetings and vocalized communiques are the norm.

Learn more about mastering the use of the written word in an all-remote setting.

### In-person interactions

While there are tremendous advantages to operating a 100% remote company, leaders should consider being intentional about planning in-person elements, even if they're optional for team members.

Learn more about considerations for in-person interactions in a remote company.

### Workspace



All-remote enables the creation of a custom office, perfectly tailored for your desires and ergonomic needs.

Learn more about key considerations when building and evolving your remote workspace.

### Parenting as a remote worker

Parents who work from home have unique demands and expectations, as well as unique challenges. Being an excellent coworker and an excellent parent is a tall order, particularly when childcare and school are impacted by a global crisis.

Learn more about balancing remote work and parenting.

### Stories

Read the stories of some of our team members and hear how remote work has impacted their lives.

### Interviews

Read and listen to interviews on the topic of working remotely, hosted by GitLab team members.

### History

Learn about historical milestones, inflection points, and prescient interviews in the evolution and expansion of remote work.

### Hybrid-remote

Hybrid-remote companies have one or more offices where a subset of the company commutes to each day, paired with a subset of the company that works remotely.

Learn more about advantages, challenges, and the primary differences between all-remote and other forms of remote working.

### Comparing All-Remote Benefits vs. Hybrid-Remote Benefits

Learn more about the differences in workplace experience by individuals who are remote by default in an all-remote setting vs. a hybrid-remote setting, working with colleagues who are onsite by default.

### Transitioning or adding remote

Learn more about considerations for transitioning a colocated or hybrid-remote company to 100% remote.

### What not to do when implementing remote

An organization should not attempt to merely replicate the in-office/colocated experience, remotely.

Learn more about what not to do when transitioning to remote, or moving towards remote.

### Working while traveling

Working remotely enables a tremendous amount of freedom, enabling team members to work from anywhere so long as there is a reliable internet connection.

Learn more about optimizing comfort and efficiency when taking your office with you while traveling.

### Remote work conferences, summits, and events

Particularly for those who are seeking a new role with an all-remote or remote-first company, events can be a great place to meet others who have experience and connections in the space.

Learn more about remote work conferences and summits, the power of networking, and the unique elements of experiencing a virtual event.

### Remote internships

Remote internships are unique in one primary way: there is no physical office involved.

Learn more about considerations for both employee and employer as it relates to remote internships (also referred to as apprenticeships and co-ops).

### All-remote Certification

GitLab is a pioneer in the all-remote space. As one of the world's largest all-remote companies, we have developed a custom certification program to test and apply knowledge attained throughout the all-remote section of the handbook. Emerging leaders must quickly learn and deploy remote-first practices and skills while expanding their knowledge of remote management and overall remote fluency.

### Remote work guides for teams

These remote work guides are written specifically for external parties who wish to learn how specific divisions/departments function in a remote environment.

Remote Guide for Finance Teams  
{.h3}

Remote Guide for Design Teams  
{.h3}

Remote Guide for People Operations  
{.h3}

Remote Guide for Legal Teams  
{.h3}

## All-remote Pick Your Brain interviews

If people want advice on structuring or managing an all-remote organization, we'd love to connect. Learn more about requesting a Pick Your Brain interview on all-remote.

Contribute to this page

At GitLab, we recognize that the whole idea of all-remote organizations is still quite new, and can only be successful with active participation from the whole community. Here's how you can participate:

- Propose or suggest any change to this site by a merge request.
- Create an issue if you have any questions or if you see an inconsistency.
- Help spread the word about all-remote organizations by sharing it on social media.

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## SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/guide/design.md

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With forethought and planning, active resiliency in the face of a sudden all-remote change can actually serve to enhance productivity. This guide outlines how design teams can optimally prepare for and navigate these sudden changes to an all-remote environment.

Thinking strategically, acting creatively

Design teams must develop a strategy to operate suddenly in an all-remote environment. The main concepts to consider are the following:

1. Communication Infrastructure: In a remote environment it's important design teams implement purposeful communications. Start with an agenda, both to keep attendees focused and to keep non-attendees in the loop. Using Google Docs, for example, allows everyone to contribute ideas, comment on concepts, and document decisions. To compensate for the shift to all-remote, it's wise to establish broad and frequent communications.
1. Collaboration Cadence: In an office environment, design teams organically build and fall into a cadence of meetings, collaboration, and other team-based activities. When these in-person exchanges are not available, it's important design teams establish asynchronous workflows and learn how to collaborate through text.
1. Leadership and Empathy: The way design team leaders operate and exercise management oversight must change to reflect the sudden upheaval. This might entail more frequent but shorter one-on-one meetings to sustain a pulse on team members or more frequent check-ins to project work teams to provide support. Bottom line: how leaders managed in traditional environments will not translate directly or neatly into a suddenly all-remote one. Read our all-remote management guide on effective all-remote leadership for more information.
1. Metrics: If "out of sight, out o